PLA incursions blocked access to some. No-patrol areas at the PLA's farthest reaches of ingress thus go against Indian interests, giving weight to the concern that the creation of buffer zones has led to India losing control of territory it perceived as its own and had traditionally patrolled as such.

Furthermore, it is feared that the buffer zone at PP15 has cut off access for the Indian Army to PP16, known as Karam Singh Hill—where Indian forces have maintained a post for decades—near the Kugrang Valley. Again, even after the Galwan incident on June 15-16, 2020, Indian soldiers would go up to PP14 on the Galwan river. Now, jawans (and PLA troops) can no longer patrol it, as it's in the buffer zone.

While military planners claim that the areas would prevent Galwan-type clashes by keeping the opposing armies safely apart, defence experts fear that they have changed the very character of the LAC in favour of China. Lt Gen. Vinod Bhatia, former director general of military operations, says the border is a line of perception and the creation of buffer zones at friction points is the only available option to avoid physical clashes till the issue is resolved. "However, after the Galwan clash, all agreements and protocols on border management were breached by the PLA with its aggressive posturing," Lt Gen. Bhatia says.

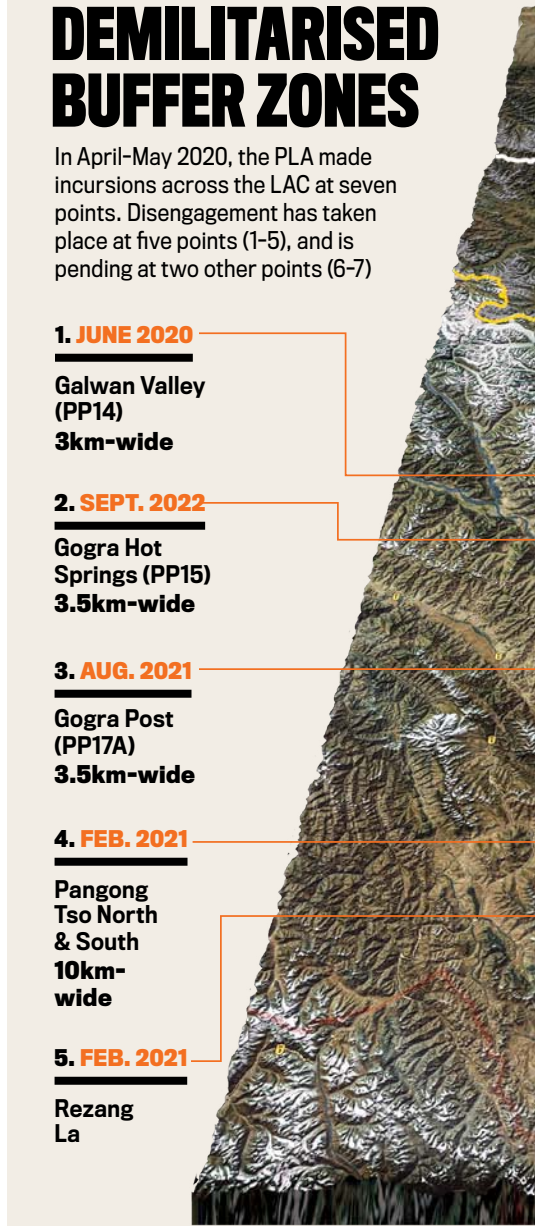
Former foreign secretary Shyam Saran says that the September 8 joint statement does not say much about what this disengagement really means and its implications. "If direct confrontation between the two forces has been ameliorated to some extent, that is certainly a welcome move. But the major cause of concern is the rapid build-up in rear areas [10-20 km behind the LAC], including new bases in Xinjiang and Tibet that have been set up. We really do need to take a comprehensive view on what really is happening," Saran adds.

Both armies have around 50,000-60,000 troops, as well as tanks, artillery pieces and missile systems deployed along the 832km-long undemarcated LAC. Military experts opine that for the two nations to get back to the old status quo, disengagement needs to be completed at all flashpoints, with troops returning to their March 2020 positions. While the official claim is that efforts are on to de-escalate all remaining friction points, the standoff at Demchok, where the opposing armies are in a tense stand-off, could prove to be tough to wind down. Here, the PLA has blocked Indian patrols from going any further.

Lt Gen. Rakesh Sharma, former corps commander of the Leh-based 14 Corps, which looks after eastern Ladakh, says that in the past 10 years, scuffles have increased between the two sides while patrolling, in spite of clear protocols in place for avoiding such incidents. Ever since Xi took over as president, he says, the Chinese have been more aggressive, with the PLA refusing to return to its original starting points after incursions, as witnessed in 2013 in Depsang, 2014 in Chumar and 2018 in Doklam. "The Chinese refused to go back despite protocols like banner drills, leading to scuffles. And, these fights always had the possibility of escalating into something more serious, which happened in Galwan and Pangong Tso," Lt Gen. Sharma says, adding that now the calculating Chinese are insisting on buffer zones to avoid a conventional or limited conflict. The Indian military, he says, never liked the idea of having these demilitarised zones due to a lack of faith in the PLA.

DEMILITARISED BUFFER ZONES

In April-May 2020, the PLA made incursions across the LAC at seven points. Disengagement has taken place at five points (1-5), and is pending at two other points (6-7)



However, in the last few talks to resolve the standoff, in which central government officials participated, the Chinese proposed buffer zones. They have now become a feature of any disengagement negotiation. In the past, too, the Chinese sought to have buffer zones on the undemarcated border. In 1959, the Chinese offered a 20km-wide zone on either side of the LAC, with former Chinese premier Zhou Enlai writing about it to PM Jawaharlal Nehru. But India rejected it as a matter of policy. This time around, India has agreed to the Chinese demand for buffer zones at every friction point.

"It suits the Chinese to keep the Indian military under pressure by not demarcating the LAC and retaining geostrategic